

Primary Source Reading 2: The Unexamined Life

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Apology, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 1c: The Unexamined Life and the Purpose of Philosophy

Before you read: The jury has convicted Socrates. Athenian procedure now requires him to propose his own penalty, which the jury will vote to accept or reject in place of the prosecution's demand for death. Before doing so, Socrates explains why he refused, throughout his trial, to do what every other defendant did — weep, plead, and bring his family before the jury for sympathy. As you read, watch for the claim that made his sentence, and his life, worth defending: that the unexamined life is not worth living. The reading closes with Socrates' reflections on death itself, spoken to his friends after the sentence has been passed.

Why He Would Not Weep

Perhaps there may be some one who is offended at me, when he calls to mind how he himself on a similar, or even a less serious occasion, prayed and entreated the judges with many tears, and how he produced his children in court, which was a moving spectacle, together with a host of relations and friends; whereas I, who am probably in danger of my life, will do none of these things... My friend, I am a man, and like other men, a creature of flesh and blood, and not "of wood or stone," as Homer says; and I have a family, yes, and sons, O Athenians, three in number, one almost a man, and two others who are still young; and yet I will not bring any of them hither in order to petition you for an acquittal. And why not? Not from any self-assertion or want of respect for you... but, having regard to public opinion, I feel that such conduct would be discreditable to myself, and to you, and to the whole state. One who has reached my years, and who has a name for wisdom, ought not to demean himself. (34b–35a)

A Reward Instead of a Punishment

[Socrates is found guilty. Before the jury votes on his penalty, he considers, with evident irony, what he actually deserves.]

What return shall be made to the man who has never had the wit to be idle during his whole life; but has been careless of what the many care for — wealth, and family interests, and military offices, and speaking in the assembly, and magistracies, and plots, and parties. Reflecting that I was really too honest a man to be a politician and live, I did not go where I could do no good to you or to myself; but where I could do the greatest good privately to every one of you, thither I went, and sought to persuade every man among you that he must look to himself, and seek virtue and wisdom before he looks to his private interests... What would be a reward suitable to a poor

man who is your benefactor, and who desires leisure that he may instruct you? There can be no reward so fitting as maintenance in the Prytaneum, O men of Athens, a reward which he deserves far more than the citizen who has won the prize at Olympia in the horse or chariot race... For I am in want, and he has enough; and he only gives you the appearance of happiness, and I give you the reality. (36b–d)

The Greatest Good of Man

[The jury does not share his sense of irony. Socrates goes on to consider, and reject, exile as an alternative to death — since he cannot imagine ceasing to examine himself and others, wherever he lives.]

Some one will say: Yes, Socrates, but cannot you hold your tongue, and then you may go into a foreign city, and no one will interfere with you? Now I have great difficulty in making you understand my answer to this. For if I tell you that to do as you say would be a disobedience to the God, and therefore that I cannot hold my tongue, you will not believe that I am serious; and if I say again that daily to discourse about virtue, and of those other things about which you hear me examining myself and others, is the greatest good of man, and that the unexamined life is not worth living, you are still less likely to believe me. Yet I say what is true, although a thing of which it is hard for me to persuade you. (37e–38a)

On the Threshold of Death

[The jury votes for death, by a wider margin than it voted to convict. Socrates turns to speak to the friends who tried to acquit him, before he is led away.]

Hitherto the divine faculty of which the internal oracle is the source has constantly been in the habit of opposing me even about trifles, if I was going to make a slip or error in any matter; and now, as you see, there has come upon me that which may be thought, and is generally believed to be, the last and worst evil. But the oracle made no sign of opposition, either when I was leaving my house in the morning, or when I was on my way to the court, or while I was speaking, at anything which I was going to say. What do I take to be the explanation of this silence? It is an intimation that what has happened to me is a good, and that those of us who think that death is an evil are in error. (40a–c)

The Two Possibilities

Let us reflect in another way, and we shall see that there is great reason to hope that death is a good; for one of two things — either death is a state of nothingness and utter unconsciousness, or, as men say, there is a change and migration of the soul from this world to another. Now if you suppose that there is no consciousness, but a sleep like the sleep of him who is undisturbed even by dreams, death will be an unspeakable gain. For if a person were to select the night in which his sleep was undisturbed even by dreams, and were to compare with this the other days and nights of his life, and then were to tell us how many days and nights he had passed in the course of his life better and more pleasantly than this one, I think that any man... will not find many such days or nights. (40c–d)

Conversing with the Dead

But if death is the journey to another place, and there, as men say, all the dead abide, what good, O my friends and judges, can be greater than this? What would not a man give if he might converse with Orpheus and Musaeus and Hesiod and Homer? Nay, if this be true, let me die again and again... Above all, I shall then be able to continue my search into true and false knowledge; as in this world, so also in the next; and I shall find out who is wise, and who pretends to be wise, and is not. (41a–c)

The Final Word

Wherefore, O judges, be of good cheer about death, and know of a certainty, that no evil can happen to a good man, either in life or after death. He and his are not neglected by the gods; nor has my own approaching end happened by mere chance... The hour of departure has arrived, and we go our ways — I to die, and you to live. Which is better God only knows. (41c–42a)